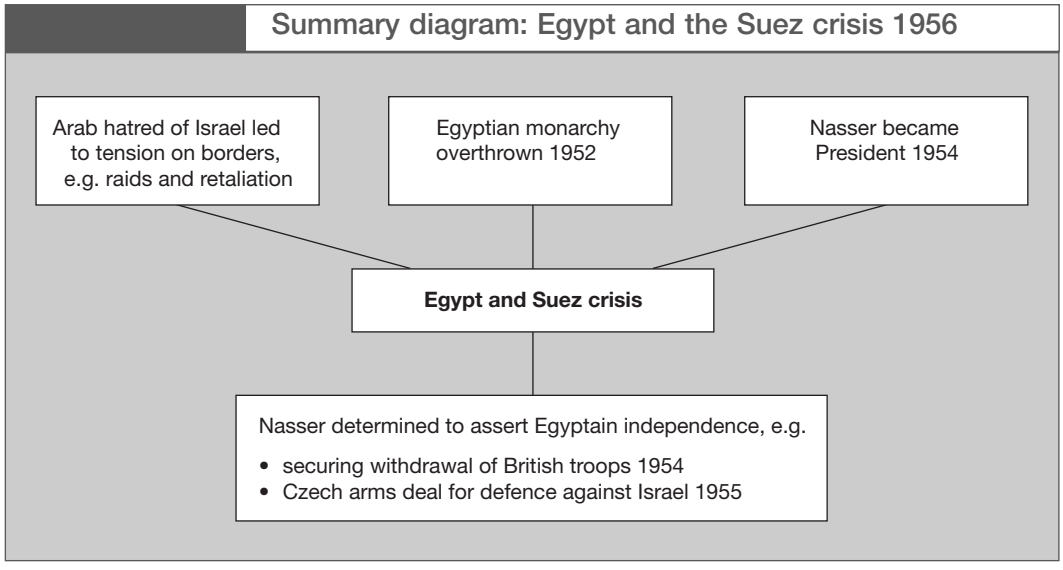


2 | The Suez War 1956

Key question
Why did Britain, France and Israel decide to attack Egypt?

Yet again, however, Nasser shocked the West. He decided on a bold and defiant move to prove that Egypt really was independent. In front of a huge crowd, on 26 July, 1956, he announced that the Suez Canal was 'our Canal'. He told the crowd: 'We dug the Canal with our lives, our skulls, our bones, our blood.'

Key date
Nationalisation of Suez Canal: July 1956

> People of Egypt. We shall maintain our independence and sovereignty. The Suez Canal Company has become our property and the Egyptian flag flies over it. We shall defend it with our blood and strength, and we shall meet aggression with aggression and evil with evil.

Key terms
Nationalise To transfer from private to government ownership.

Appease To make concessions in order to avoid conflict.

Nasser decided that Egypt would **nationalise** the Canal and Egyptians would run it themselves. They would use the profits to build the Aswan Dam. He said that Britain and France could 'choke on their rage'. This daring act thrilled the Arabs in Egypt and elsewhere.

Britain and France were furious. The British Prime Minister, Anthony Eden, was determined not to let Nasser 'have his thumb on our windpipe'. The British and French withdrew their pilots who guided ships through the Canal. But the Egyptians kept it running and the traffic increased. The French saw Nasser as 'Hitler on the Nile'. They were determined not to **appease** Nasser as they had appeased Hitler in the 1930s. They had already agreed to sell Israel over 70 fighter planes and 200 tanks. Now they held secret meetings with the Israelis in order to plot Nasser's downfall. The French had an added reason for wishing to topple Nasser: they accused him of sending weapons and other